“What did he say?”

“He trusts her.”

“It’s my fault. I’ve caused you trouble.” Her eyes dropped.

“You have nothing to be sorry for,” he said, trying to reassure her. “Your behavior has always been exemplary.”

“But my presence has led your secretary to talk about us in a way that is not . . .” Rose, searching for the right word, leaned back in the chair and crossed her legs. “I should have anticipated that she would have such a reaction.”

“How could you have?”

“I don’t know, but I shouldn’t have let it get out of control.” She kept her voice even, looking for an opening to guide their conversation around to André. If she appeared too desperate, it might make him suspicious. “Shall I stop coming? I can tell Herr Capek to deliver the reports as before.”

“No.” He squeezed the pencil, knuckles cracking. “Enough discussion of Frau Birks. How was your trip to Berlin, and your cousin?”

“It was . . .” She shook her head. “I’ve taken enough of your time.” She started to rise.

“There’s no rush. Stay a while and tell me about your cousin.”

She took a deep breath, readying herself to touch his vulnerable nerve. “He finds the situation at Tempelhof challenging.”

“In what way?”

“It’s not the work. He’s quite skilled. It’s the workers. There is only one barracks of French workers, the rest are . . .” She paused.

“Go on.” He lifted his eyes with renewed interest.

“Russian. Ten barracks of Russians. Men and women.” Her lips pinched as if she’d tasted a lemon. “They work on the assembly line together.”

“I sympathize with your cousin’s predicament. The Russians are barbaric.” He exhaled. “They killed Felix.” He gazed out the window and thought for a moment. “What does your cousin do?”

“Something about timed fuses for the bombs loaded onto the Junker.” She could see his mind turning. Recrossing her legs, she waited.

“There are companies here that perform similar work. Would your cousin want to come and work here? We have fewer Eastern workers than in Berlin, and he would also be close to you.”

Her heart hammered at the prospect that he’d taken the bait, but she